



Shah Mosque

A masterpiece of Islamic architecture reflecting the splendor of Safavid Iran



In 1598, Shah Abbas I, the greatest ruler of Iran's Shi'ite Safavid dynasty (1501–1722), decided to take Isfahan as his new capital and had the city rebuilt to reflect the secular and spiritual power of his expanding empire. The principal result was the creation of the magnificent Naqsh-e Jahan Square, bordered by the Ali Qapu royal palace; the Sheikh Lotfollah Mosque; and, above all, the immense Shah Mosque (now known in Iran as the Imam Mosque).

Color and proportion

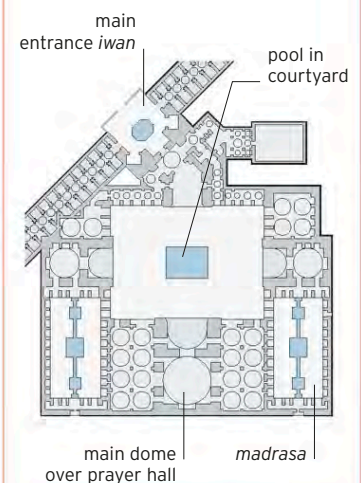
Work on the Shah Mosque began in 1611 and was completed some 20 years later. Attributed to architect Ali Akbar Isfahani, it is a vast structure incorporating two *madrasas* and a separate winter mosque. The whole building is sumptuously decorated with polychrome tiles, with turquoise and dark blue being

predominant. The focus of the mosque is the inner courtyard, built around a pool and dominated by four *iwans*, vaulted spaces open on one side. The walls of the *iwans* are embellished with tiles bearing floral motifs, and the ceilings are fine examples of the "stalactite" style known as *muqarnas*. The mosque is topped by a double-shelled dome, the outer shell rising to a height of 174 ft (53 m) and the inner shell reaching 125 ft (38 m) above the mosque floor. The exterior surface of the dome, covered in brilliant turquoise tiles, reflects sunlight to dazzling effect.

The Shah Mosque is very much a living center of worship for Iranian Muslims today, but non-Muslim visitors are also warmly welcomed. A major tourist attraction, the entirety of Naqsh-e Jahan Square, including the mosque, was designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1979.

COMPLEX LAYOUT

The Shah Mosque is oriented toward Mecca, to the southwest of Isfahan, which places it at an angle to Naqsh-e Jahan Square, which is built on a north-south axis. Thus, the entrance from the colonnaded facade on the square twists through 45 degrees to the *iwan* leading into the central courtyard. The domed main prayer hall is flanked by two *madrasas*.



Some **18 million bricks** and **475,000 tiles** were used in the **construction** of the **Shah Mosque**